CHAPTER 37

CAPTAIN COOK

13–17 December 2012

INDIA vs ENGLAND, 4th Test, *Nagpur, India*

England 330 and 352/4 dec.; India 326/9 dec.

Match drawn (England won the series 2-1)

India 1st innings: **J Anderson 32–5–81–4**

There is one thing that the Strauss and Flower legacy didn't do – win in India. An England side hasn't won there since 1984–85, when I was two years old. With Flower still in charge, and some heavy hearts at the injustice of how Andrew Strauss had to go, it's probably a necessarily large task ahead of us to refocus the group. Alastair Cook has been handed the captaincy of the Test side and the first thing he is tasked with – unenviably – is the 'reintegrating' of KP. He does it quickly, without much fuss. I think he knows that, firstly, it will be something that will follow him around until he does, and secondly, Kevin is going to be essential in India if we are to have any chance at all.

There are small pockets of groups in the team – as there are in any social group – and an element of different friendship groups, but the atmosphere between everyone is very healthy. Rocked by the loss against South Africa, there is a determination to achieve something and arrest a downward curve. The team is too full of tough, thoughtful, determined cricketers to be immediately jettisoned by a soap opera and a motivated South Africa. There is a newness to the side, a fierce commitment to it on both a personal and collective level.